

orders were customarily received. Having bypassed the normal step of calling in my order to a broker, and the broker calling the order desk, I told Mr. Flippen what I intended to buy. He wrote it down on a scrap of paper and stamped the paper into a time clock. It was the Japanese-yen option Mr. Epstein had recommended.

The Japanese-yen option worked the same way as the option on the basket of stocks I'd bought earlier in New York. It gave me the right to purchase a futures contract on several million Japanese yen anytime from now until the expiration date. Actually, I sought to buy two yen options with a September expiration, which were selling for about \$215 apiece.

"Wanna see your order filled?" said Mr. Flippen. "Follow me." We left the telephone desk and skirted a stock-option pit, which at floor level seemed as lively as a cockfight in Tijuana. The Japanese-yen-option pit was relatively quiet. At most, there were 50 traders standing in the ring, with the greatest density toward the center.

Mr. Flippen handed my scrap of paper to a man with a ponytail who wore badge K-62. He grabbed the paper, turned away from us, and yelled into the pit: "Two calls. Two hundred and fourteen dollars on one. September. Two calls." After a few seconds, K-62 reversed direction, scribbled something on the paper, and handed it to Mr. Flippen.

"That's it," said Mr. Flippen, who then introduced K-62 as Howard Schless. K-62 shook my hand and started to tell me something, then mumbled a quick "I'm busy" and disappeared into the pit. "He can't talk now," said Mr. Flippen. "But did you notice what he did? Did you see the \$215 offer over on the other side? Howard could have taken that, but he waited and bid you lower and got you the \$214. That's the sign of a good trader. It's the cripples you gotta watch out for."

As we walked back to the order desk to record our trade, Mr. Flippen explained what he meant by cripples. A cripple was an indifferent trader who got less than optimum prices for his clients, either paying too much on the buy side or asking too little on the sell. Though I hadn't even seen the actual trade, I was grateful that K-62 Schless had saved me the dollar. Already, I was begin-